DEFENSIVE CYBERSECURITY EXERCISE

Operation Silent Ridge

A patrol's movement details may have leaked.

Your team finds out what happened — and proves it.



EVENT DAY BRIEFING · ALL CONTENT FICTIONAL · READ-ONLY INVESTIGATION

BEFORE WE START

Two things to learn in the next ten minutes

01

The story — what happened at 09:30 this morning

A fictional patrol is in the field and its movement details may have been disclosed. You are the incoming SOC shift. Everything you investigate is fictional, pre-collected, and safe to touch.

02

Your setup — four browser tabs and one desktop

We walk through every login, click by click, until your team has claimed its first ticket and answered its first question. No prior knowledge assumed.

WHEN WE'RE DONE

You will know the incident story, be logged into everything, and have points on the board. Then the exercise clock starts for real.

PART 1 · THE STORY

09:30 UTC: the outgoing shift hands you a problem

Patrol **LANTERN** is already in the field. The outgoing shift suspects its movement details were disclosed — an account password was reset at 09:20, and a viewer tool was run minutes later. Endpoint, network, identity, document-service and SIEM exports are already collected.

No confirmed harm. Do not assume it is over.

WHAT WE KNOW

- A password reset happened at 09:20 UTC
- A viewer tool was downloaded and accessed a browser session store
- All evidence exports are already collected and waiting for you

WHAT WE DON'T KNOW

- Which movements were exposed, and to whom
- How access was gained
- Which systems are still affected
- Whether the incident has ended

WHAT YOU DO ABOUT IT

- Investigate the evidence in teams
- Label every claim: confirmed, assessed, or unknown
- Build a defensible shared assessment before the day ends

All names, hosts, addresses and artifacts are fictional exercise material. Nothing here is a real system or person.

PART 1 · THE STORY

How the day works: claim, investigate, answer, share

1 · CLAIM
Pick an open ticket in the IRIS queue. One active ticket per team.

→

2 · INVESTIGATE
Use the desktop tools on the released evidence. Read-only, always.

→

3 · ANSWER
Submit the requested value in CTFd. One point per correct answer.

→

4 · SHARE
The finding publishes to IRIS for every team. Closed tickets unlock new ones.

WORTH KNOWING UP FRONT

· **Hints are free.** Every question has help levels; using them costs nothing.

· **Wrong answers cost nothing.** You only ever gain points — try, read the next hint, try again.

· **Stuck?** Relinquish the ticket in IRIS so another team can continue it. Your solved questions stay solved and your points stay yours.

· **No reports, no approvals.** Answering questions and sharing findings is the whole job.

PART 2 · YOUR SETUP

Your kit: four tabs in your own browser, one shared desktop

TAB / APP	ADDRESS	WHAT IT'S FOR
IRIS — incident queue	:8081	Claim and relinquish tickets; read shared findings as they publish
CTFd — questions	:8083	See your ticket's questions, submit answers, watch the scoreboard
Wazuh — log search	:8443 (HTTPS)	Search the historical SIEM records for your ticket's time range
Team desktop	:8082	The only thing that needs the remote desktop: Autopsy, Wireshark, Cutter, files

THE ONE RULE THAT KEEPS THINGS FAST

Do all browsing in **your own laptop browser**. Inside the shared desktop, use only the investigation tools — a browser opened in there slows the desktop down for your whole team.

1 Open your handout and log into IRIS

DO THIS NOW

1. Find your team handout (paper or message from your facilitator).

It lists your team's logins and the event addresses.

2. Open a browser tab and go to the IRIS address:

```
https://<event-address>:8081
```

3. Log in with your **team** IRIS login
(looks like **team-04**) and the password from the handout.

4. You should see the incident ticket queue.

If you do, this step is done.

HOW TO CHECK

You see a list of tickets with statuses like **available**.

Login failed? Re-read the team name — it is the team login,
not your personal seat login.

IRIS is where work is claimed. Nobody can answer questions for a ticket until some team owns it.

2 Open CTFd in a second tab and log in as yourself

DO THIS NOW

1. Open a second tab:

```
https://<event-address>:8083
```

2. Log in with **your personal seat** login —

it looks like **team-04-p02** — and the seat password from the handout.

Each teammate uses their own seat.

3. You land on the question queue.

It may be nearly empty — questions appear here only for tickets your team owns.

4. Open the **Scoreboard** link.

All teams start at zero.

HOW TO CHECK

You can see the question queue and the scoreboard.

A 403 or "no permission" page means you used the team IRIS login here — switch to your seat login.

CTFd is where answers are checked and points are earned. Points belong to the team, no matter which seat submits.

3 Open your team's shared desktop

DO THIS NOW

1. Third tab:

`https://<event-address>:8082`

2. Log in with the **Guacamole** username and password from the handout, then click your team's desktop connection.

3. If the desktop asks for a password, it is the **VNC password** on the handout.

4. You are now sharing one Linux desktop with your whole team — take turns driving. Evidence lives under **/evidence**; the prepared case lives in the home folder.

HOW TO CHECK

You see a Linux desktop with icons for **Autopsy**, **Wireshark** and **Cutter**, and a file manager that opens **/evidence**.

One desktop per team, several of you connected at once. Everything here is read-only exercise material — you cannot break the evidence.

4 Claim your first ticket, answer your first question

DO THIS NOW — AS A TEAM

1. In the IRIS tab, find a ticket marked **available** and press **Claim ticket**. Your team now owns it.

2. Switch to the CTFd tab — the ticket's questions are visible. Open one; help levels 1 and 2 are free.

3. Investigate with the tool the question names (next page shows all five).

4. Type the requested value and press **Check answer**. Correct: four points and an IRIS finding. Level 3 is the full walkthrough; unlocking it costs 75%, leaving one point.

HOW TO CHECK

The scoreboard shows your team above zero, and the finding appears in IRIS within about ten seconds.

Finishing every question on a ticket closes it and unlocks follow-up tickets. That is the whole rhythm — repeat until the day ends.

PART 2 · YOUR SETUP

Five tools, five jobs — the question always names its tool

TOOL	QUESTIONS	WHAT YOU DO WITH IT
Autopsy	32 of 80	Open the prepared case on the desktop; browse files, search keywords, inspect the artifacts the question points at
Wazuh	24 of 80	In your own browser (:8443): Discover → historical data view → set the UTC range in the question, then filter one step at a time
Wireshark	8 of 80	Open the capture under /evidence/network; apply the display filter the question suggests (e.g. udp.port == 514)
Cutter	8 of 80	Static analysis only — open the training binary, read strings and named functions; never debug or run it
File manager	8 of 80	Walk the /evidence tree and read files directly — the simplest tool, try it first when unsure

IF A TOOL FEELS FOREIGN

Help levels 1 and 2 are free. If you still need it, unlock level 3 for a complete walkthrough; it costs 75% of that question's points so your team can keep moving.

GROUND RULES

Rules of engagement: four yes, four no

YES — DO

· **Use UTC** for evidence times and elapsed minutes for exercise deadlines

· **Label every claim** confirmed, assessed (with confidence), or unknown

· **Cite the evidence** — file, host, timestamp — behind every answer

· **Share and ask** — findings are shared by design; read other teams' completed findings to see the wider incident

NO — DON'T

· **Never execute evidence** — no running binaries, scripts or documents found in the material

· **Never scan or contact** external systems, and never direct real personnel "in the field"

· **Don't invent harm**, adversary names, or movements the evidence doesn't show

· **Don't browse inside the desktop** — keep it fast for your team's tools

Every address, identity and artifact in this exercise is fictional. The defensive habits above are the real takeaway — they are what makes an assessment defensible.

WHEN THINGS GO WRONG

If something breaks: what to try before raising a hand

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
“Connection interrupted” on the question page	Wait a few seconds and retry — accepted answers are retained; nothing you earned is lost
Points or findings not showing yet	Give it about ten seconds — scoring and findings synchronize in the background
Desktop frozen or disconnected	Reconnect from the :8082 tab; the desktop and your case are exactly where you left them
Login refused everywhere	Check you're on the right app with the right login kind (team vs seat vs Guacamole), then ask a facilitator

STILL STUCK

Raise a hand. Facilitators can pause the exercise clock, recover a stuck ticket, or re-issue a login — you cannot break the exercise by asking.

YOU'RE READY

Success today looks like this

· A **defensible shared assessment** of what happened to LANTERN — every claim labeled and cited

· **Timely updates** — brief even when confidence is low

· **Proportionate recommendations** — no invented harm, no guesswork presented as fact

· Points on the board are the byproduct, not the goal

YOUR FOUR ADDRESSES

IRIS :8081 · CTFd :8083 · Wazuh :8443 (HTTPS) · Team desktop :8082

All in your own browser. All fictional. Good hunting.